

TEACHING & RESEARCH DESIGN

SCENARIO 2 - GLOBAL TEAM, SHIFTING REQUIREMENTS

THE STORY

LearnLoop is a startup that just raised 3.2M EUR to build an AI-powered adaptive learning platform for universities. 12 people, three cities, very different skill sets:

(1) Amsterdam (UTC+1) – **4 people:**

Product managers, UX designers, 1 frontend developer

Strength: user research, product vision, GDPR knowledge

Weakness: no ML or backend expertise

(2) Bangalore (UTC+5:30) - **5 people:**

Backend engineers, ML engineers, 1 DevOps engineer

Strength: recommendation systems, scalable infrastructure

Weakness: no direct contact with end users or customers

(3) Austin (UTC-6) - **3 people:**

Business development, data analyst, customer success

Strength: weekly calls with the pilot customer (University of Texas)

Weakness: no technical or product background

Timezone reality:

Amsterdam <-> Bangalore: 4.5h gap - small morning overlap only

Amsterdam <-> Austin: 7h gap - small evening overlap only

Bangalore <-> Austin: 11.5h gap - nearly zero overlap

The first pilot customer wants a working MVP (Minimum Viable Product) in 9 months.

After the first stakeholder workshops, three problems surface immediately:

(1) Nobody at the university agrees on what the platform should do.

IT wants LMS integration. Professors want content control.

Students want to see why a recommendation was made.

Legal wants FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act) compliance before any student data is processed.

(2) Austin collects new requirements every week in customer calls,

but there is no process to pass them to Amsterdam or Bangalore.

(3) Bangalore has already started building the recommendation engine -

but Amsterdam has not yet decided what data the platform will collect.

Two engineers are frustrated because they keep receiving design mockups that are architecturally impossible to implement.

The CEO is optimistic. The team is not.

TASK 1 - ANALYSE

a. Which Scrum elements create specific problems here? (Bullets points are fine)

Scrum Element	Still works?	Why / Why not?
2 – week sprints	No	Due to large time zone differences and lack of synchronous collaboration, tasks may not be prioritized effectively within short sprints.
Definition of Done	No	The definition may lack clarity, especially across teams that have not aligned on requirements, leading to differing interpretations.
Backlog prioritization	No	Without a unified approach to gather and prioritize requirements, the backlog is ineffective and hinders progress.
Sprint Review Demo	No	If there are disagreements on what was built or if features are technically infeasible, reviews may not provide meaningful feedback.
Velocity tracking	No	The lack of consistent work output due to miscommunication and misunderstood requirements complicates the measurement of team velocity.

TASK 2 - DECIDE

Three situations. For each: pick one option and justify your choice.

"We would do both" is not an answer.

SITUATION A - WHOSE DESIGN WINS?

Amsterdam has designed a user interface that requires real-time personalisation data streamed from the backend.

Bangalore says this is technically impossible with the current architecture - a full redesign would take 3 months.

You have 9 months until the MVP deadline.

You cannot do a 3-month redesign AND build all features in time.

You have three options:

(1) Amsterdam adapts the design to fit the current architecture.

Risk: the user experience becomes significantly worse.

(2) Bangalore does the redesign. Sprint 1-6 produce almost nothing visible, putting the 9-month deadline at serious risk.

(3) Ship the MVP with the weaker UX (option 1), then redesign after the pilot customer has seen it.

a. Which do you choose?

<< I would choose option (1) — Amsterdam adapts the design to fit the current architecture.

- b. Who has the authority to make this call - and what happens if Amsterdam and Bangalore cannot agree?
- << The Product Manager in Amsterdam has the authority to make this call. If they cannot agree, a higher-level meeting involving all relevant stakeholders should be convened to prioritize the MVP delivery deadlines.

SITUATION B - THE ONLY MEETING SLOT

You have exactly one 90-minute slot per week where all three teams can meet synchronously (15:00-16:30 Amsterdam time).

This week you have three agenda items that are all critical:

- (1) Finalise the data model - Bangalore is blocked without this.
- (2) Review 6 new requirements from the university - Austin needs a decision before the next customer call on Friday.
- (3) Resolve the Amsterdam/Bangalore architecture conflict from Situation A - it has been unresolved for 2 weeks.

You can cover two of the three properly in 90 minutes.

- a. Which item do you drop from the live meeting?
- << I would drop agenda item (3) — resolving the Amsterdam/Bangalore architecture conflict.
- b. How do you handle it differently so it does not stall the team?
- << Instead, I would schedule a smaller follow-up meeting focused solely on the architectural conflict, ensuring all relevant stakeholders participate to resolve it without derailing the main meeting's focus on urgent requirements and data modeling.

SITUATION C - THE LEGAL BLOCKER

Halfway through Sprint 3, Austin calls with urgent news:

the University of Texas legal team has blocked all student data collection until a FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act) compliance agreement is signed. Signing takes 6-8 weeks minimum.

Bangalore is currently mid-sprint, building the recommendation engine that depends entirely on that student data.

You have three options:

(1) Stop Bangalore's work immediately. Wait 6-8 weeks.

Cost: 6-8 weeks of lost development time and team frustration.

(2) Continue building the engine on synthetic (fake) data.

Risk: the engine may need significant rework once real data arrives and behaves differently than expected.

(3) Redirect Bangalore to a different part of the product

(e.g., the LMS integration) while legal is resolved.

Risk: context switching costs and the engine falls further behind.

a. Which option do you choose?

<< I would choose option (2) — continue building the engine on synthetic data.

b. How do you communicate this decision to the Bangalore team?

<< I would communicate this decision to the Bangalore team by emphasizing the importance of maintaining momentum while also acknowledging the potential risks,

assuring them that the team will adapt the engine as needed once real data is available.

TASK 3 - REFLECT

In 2-3 sentences:

- a. Which situation revealed the biggest structural weakness in how LearnLoop is organised?
<< The biggest structural weakness revealed is the lack of effective communication and alignment mechanisms across the dispersed teams, leading to conflicting priorities and incomplete requirements understanding.
- b. What would need to change in the company to make that situation not happen in the first place?
<< To prevent such situations, the company should establish a structured communication protocol, including regular cross-team syncs focused specifically on clarifying and agreeing upon shared goals and requirements ahead of development.

EXTRA TASK – RATE

Rate the reflexionbot in 2-3 sentences:

<< The reflexionbot provided a methodical and structured analysis, encouraging clear reasoning with relevant perspectives. The questions were well-aimed, guiding toward deeper reflection and decision-making strategies. However, some responses could benefit from more clarification on potential risks associated with certain choices.